

DEBUGGING HUMAN COMMUNICATION

Design Your Communication Experiment

An 8-Step Workbook for Better Conversations

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Communication Is a System

When a conversation goes sideways, there's a reason. And like any system, you can analyze what happened, form a hypothesis, test a new approach, and iterate.

This workbook walks you through an eight-step process for designing your own communication experiment. The steps are organized into three phases:

OBSERVE

1. Find a Friction Point
2. Gather Context

HYPOTHESIZE

3. Define Success
4. Identify Variables
5. Form Hypothesis

EXPERIMENT

6. Make it Measurable
7. Run an Experiment
8. Follow What Works

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Work through the steps in order. Each one builds on the last. Along the way, you'll follow **Alex** — a project lead working through their own communication challenge — so you can see each step in action before you try it yourself.

Meet Alex

Alex leads a cross-functional project team. Every week, they present a status update and ask, *"Does anyone have questions or concerns?"* They always get silence. Then, two days later, three people message them separately on Slack saying the deadline is unrealistic.

Sound familiar? Alex is going to work through the eight steps alongside you. Their example will show you what each step looks like in practice, so when it's your turn, you'll know exactly what to do.

As you follow along, you'll see Alex's progress in boxes like this:

ALEX'S EXAMPLE

This is where you'll see how Alex approaches each step. Read it first, then complete your own exercise below.

Now, think about your own friction point. It doesn't have to be the same as Alex's — any recurring communication moment that isn't working is fair game. Let's start.

PHASE 1

Observe

Before you can improve a conversation, you need to see it clearly. Observation means noticing what actually happened — without judgment, without fixing, without jumping to solutions.

Step 1: Find a Friction Point

Step 2: Gather Context

OBSERVE

STEP 1

Find a Friction Point

A friction point is a specific moment where communication breaks down. Not a vague frustration — a concrete instance. The kind of moment where you replay the conversation afterward and think, *"That didn't go the way I wanted."*

The more specific, the better. "My team meetings are unproductive" is too broad. "When I asked for questions and got silence" is a friction point.

ALEX'S EXAMPLE

I asked my team if there were any concerns about the timeline and got complete silence. Two days later, three people messaged me separately on Slack saying they thought the deadline was unrealistic.

YOUR TURN

List three conversations that didn't go the way you wanted. Be specific — the person, the setting, the moment.

1.

2.

3.

Circle or star the one that bothers you most. That's your friction point for the rest of this workbook.

OBSERVE

STEP 2

Gather Context

Communication doesn't happen in a vacuum. The same words land differently depending on who's involved, what just happened, and what pressures are in play. Before you form a hypothesis, map the terrain.

ALEX'S EXAMPLE

Weekly standup, 8 people on Zoom. I'm the project lead but don't manage anyone directly. The meeting was rushed — 25 minutes for updates from 4 workstreams. Cameras off. Everyone seemed distracted. I asked my question in the last 2 minutes.

YOUR TURN

Who was involved? What is your relationship to them?

What was the setting? (Meeting, Slack, 1:1, email, public forum?)

What was each person's goal in this conversation?

What was the emotional temperature? What happened right before?

PHASE 2

Hypothesize

Now that you've observed the situation clearly, it's time to get analytical. What does better look like? What factors are in play? And what specific change do you predict will make a difference?

Step 3: Define Success

Step 4: Identify Variables

Step 5: Form Hypothesis

HYPOTHESIZE

STEP 3

Define Success

You can't tell if something worked if you don't know what "working" looks like. Before you try to fix anything, get concrete about the outcome you're aiming for. Not "*communicate better*" — that's too vague. What would you see, hear, or feel?

ALEX'S EXAMPLE

Success = at least one person raises a real concern during the meeting itself, instead of telling me on Slack two days later. I walk away feeling like I have an accurate picture of where the project stands.

YOUR TURN

What would the other person do or say differently?

What would you do or say differently?

Write a one-sentence definition of success:

Identify Variables

Every conversation has factors that influence the outcome. Some you can control — your words, your timing, your tone. Some you can't — the other person's mood, organizational pressures, history. A good experiment targets something within your control.

ALEX'S EXAMPLE

Can control: *how I phrase the question, when in the meeting I ask it, how long I wait for an answer.* **Can't control:** *whether people feel safe speaking up, the camera-off culture, the org's general conflict avoidance.*

Lever: ***how I phrase the question.***

YOUR TURN

WHAT I CAN CONTROL	WHAT I CAN'T CONTROL

Look at the left column. **Circle the one variable you most want to experiment with.** That's your lever.

HYPOTHESIZE

STEP 5

Form Hypothesis

A hypothesis is a testable prediction: **IF** I change [specific behavior], **THEN** [specific outcome] will happen. The key word is *specific*. Vague hypotheses produce vague results.

Too vague: "If I communicate better, things will improve."

Testable: "If I ask one clarifying question before responding to criticism, THEN the other person will elaborate instead of shutting down."

ALEX'S EXAMPLE

If I replace "Any questions?" with a specific prompt like "What's one thing about this timeline that worries you?" and wait 10 full seconds, THEN at least one person will respond with a real concern.

YOUR TURN

Write two or three IF/THEN hypotheses. Star the one you want to test first.

Hypothesis A:

IF I _____, THEN
_____.

Hypothesis B:

IF I _____, THEN
_____.

Hypothesis C (optional):

IF I _____, THEN
_____.

PHASE 3

Experiment

You've observed the situation and formed a prediction. Now it's time to test it. Design your measurement, run the experiment in a real conversation, and pay attention to what actually happens.

Step 6: Make it Measurable

Step 7: Run an Experiment

Step 8: Follow What Works

EXPERIMENT

STEP 6

Make It Measurable

Communication experiments don't need laboratory precision. But you do need to know what to pay attention to. Decide this *before* you run the experiment, so you're not just going on vibes afterward.

ALEX'S EXAMPLE

During: Count seconds of silence after I ask. Note who unmutes. Watch for chat messages. **After:** Count how many concerns come via Slack in the next 48 hours (my usual signal of hidden disagreement). **Baseline:** 1 out of 5 — concerns always surface on Slack, never live.

YOUR TURN

What will you observe during the conversation?

What will you check after the conversation?

On a scale of 1–5, how would you rate this conversation today? (Your baseline.)

EXPERIMENT

STEP 7

Run an Experiment

This is where the work leaves the page. Pick a specific, upcoming opportunity to try your experiment. The smaller the stakes, the better for your first run — you're building a skill, not performing under pressure.

ALEX'S EXAMPLE

When: Thursday's standup. **Script:** Instead of "Any questions?", I'll say: "What's one thing about this timeline that worries you?" Then I'll count to 10 silently before saying anything else. **What might be hard:** The silence will feel uncomfortable. My instinct will be to fill it or say "Okay great, moving on."

YOUR TURN

When will you run it? (Name a specific conversation or meeting.)

What exactly will you do or say? Write your script.

What might make this hard? What could pull you back to your default?

EXPERIMENT

STEP 8

Follow What Works

After you run the experiment, resist the urge to judge it as "success" or "failure." Instead, get curious. What happened? What surprised you? Every result — even an unexpected one — is data.

ALEX'S EXAMPLE

*Two people spoke up. The silence felt uncomfortable at 6 seconds, but someone unmuted at 8. The specific question mattered more than the pause — one person said, "Oh, I thought you were just being polite before. This felt like you actually wanted to know." Zero Slack follow-ups in 48 hours. **Rating: 4/5.** Next experiment: try opening with the question instead of saving it for the end.*

YOUR TURN

Complete this section after you've run your experiment.

What happened? Describe the moment you tried your experiment.

What surprised you?

Rate this conversation 1–5. (Compare to your baseline.)

What will you try next?

Keep Experimenting

You just designed your first communication experiment. That's a big deal — most people never stop to analyze *why* a conversation went wrong, let alone form a hypothesis and test a new approach. The process gets easier each time. And when you're ready for support, here are two ways to keep going.

Join the Community

\$29

One-time fee, lifetime access

You don't have to figure this out alone. Join a community of people who are running their own communication experiments and learning from each other.

- ✓ Share your friction points and get feedback on your hypotheses from peers
- ✓ See how others are designing and running their experiments
- ✓ Community events, book clubs, and deliberate practice groups

debugginghumancommunication.com/community

Debug Your First Challenge

\$129

30-minute private coaching call

Walk through these 8 steps with a coach who does this every day. You'll leave with a documented experiment designed for your specific situation.

- ✓ Work through the full framework on your real challenge
- ✓ Password-protected session recording you can revisit anytime
- ✓ Documented experiment report: hypothesis, behavior changes, and your concrete next step

100% Money-Back Guarantee. If you don't feel you've gotten your money's worth, I'll refund you completely. Keep the recording and the report — no questions asked.

Book Your Session → debugginghumancommunication.com/discovery

Communication is a system you can understand, debug, and systematically improve. Each experiment sharpens your instincts. Come back to this workbook anytime you hit a new friction point.

— Andrea Goulet